

WIL302 — Assessment 1

INITIAL STUDIO RESEARCH & DOCUMENTATION

Kira Zakirov

Torrens University Australia

Bachelor of Game Design & Development

Internship: CSM Security Solutions

Trimester 3, 2026

PART A — GAP ANALYSIS

I am undertaking my internship as a software developer at CSM SEC, an Australian wholesale distributor of security solutions — CCTV, access control, intercoms, and digital locking — supplying a large, multi-brand catalogue to security professionals across the country. I received the project scope document on 23 June, and we are currently in the process of discussing the finer details — what software stack to use, what features are in and out of scope, and how the application will function for their team.

My Expectations

My degree in Game Design and Development has centred on iterative, studio-based development, software engineering fundamentals, and a strong focus on user experience and production pipelines. Going into this internship, I expected to transfer those skills from a game context into a real business application: taking ownership of a genuine piece of software rather than isolated exercises, designing it from the ground up, and choosing my own technology stack. As my course also includes a dedicated Portfolio subject, I expected a project strong enough to showcase professionally. I also expected to behave professionally — meeting deadlines, communicating proactively, respecting confidentiality, and dressing appropriately for the office.

Employer's Expectations

My employer wants me to build a web application for internal stocktaking — a tool that allows warehouse staff to search products, scan barcodes, and record physical counts during a stocktake session. The current process relies on a static Excel spreadsheet exported from NetSuite, which has no multi-user access, no audit trail, and no real-time progress tracking. I have complete freedom over technologies and implementation, and confidentiality applies as set out in the WIL Agreement I signed.

The Gap

The main gap is not core skill but process and domain. I have the technical ability to build the application, but the security-distribution industry is new to me, and working directly with a client — negotiating scope, managing expectations, and making decisions without a supervisor approving each step — is a different dynamic from university projects. Additionally, the scope is still being refined through ongoing discussions, so I need to remain flexible while keeping the project on track.

Strategies to Bridge the Gap

I am bridging this gap by staying actively involved in the scoping discussions — asking targeted questions, documenting decisions as they are made, and preparing a structured technical response to ensure both sides are aligned before development begins. I am also researching the domain independently to better understand CSM's products and workflows. This approach aligns with what Boud and Solomon (2001) describe as the core value of work integrated learning: developing professional competence not through instruction, but through navigating real workplace challenges where ambiguity is part of the process.



Kira Zakirov
 Jun 15 16:06 | Last edited Jul 8 18:34
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Gap Analysis & Expectations

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My expectations. My degree in Game Design and Development has centred on iterative, studio-based development, software engineering fundamentals, and a strong focus on user experience and production pipelines. Going into this internship, I expected to transfer those skills from a game context into a real business application: taking ownership of a genuine piece of software rather than isolated exercises, designing it from the ground up, and choosing my own technology stack. As my course also includes a dedicated Portfolio subject, I expected a project strong enough to showcase professionally. I also expected to behave professionally — meeting deadlines, communicating proactively, respecting confidentiality, and dressing appropriately for the office.

My employer's expectations. My employer wants me to build a web application for internal stocktaking — a tool that allows warehouse staff to search products, scan barcodes, and record physical counts during a stocktake session. The current process relies on a static Excel spreadsheet exported from NetSuite, which has no multi-user access, no audit trail, and no real-time progress tracking. I have complete freedom over technologies and implementation, and confidentiality applies as set out in the WIL Agreement I signed.

Gap analysis. The main gap is not core skills but processes and domains. I have the technical ability to build the application. Still, the security-distribution industry is new to me, and working directly with a client — negotiating scope, managing expectations, and making decisions without a supervisor approving each step — is a different dynamic from university projects. Additionally, the scope is still being refined through ongoing discussions, so I need to remain flexible while keeping the project on track.

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 Reply
  Mark as Unread

Figure 1 — Gap Analysis & Expectations forum post (Module 1 Discussion Forum)

PART B — STRENGTHS ANALYSIS

I completed the VIA Character Strengths survey (VIA Institute on Character, 2026) to identify my core character strengths. My top five results are shown below.

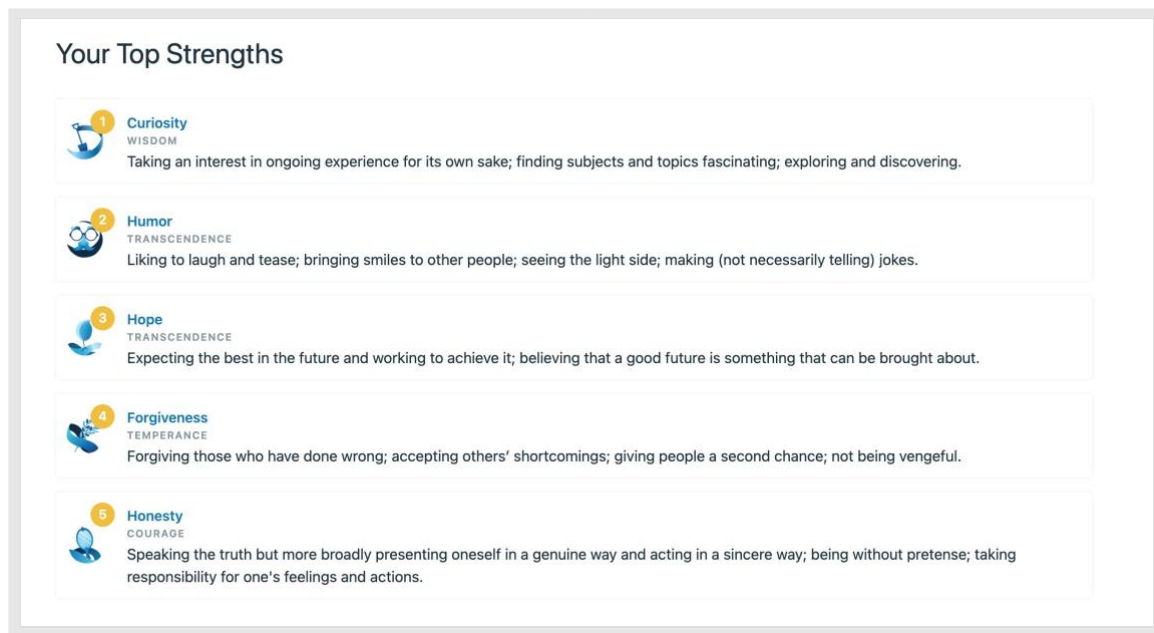


Figure 2 — VIA Character Strengths: Top 5 results

Reflection

Curiosity resonated with me immediately and feels like the most accurate result. As a software developer, curiosity drives me to explore new technologies, dig into documentation, and understand how systems work beneath the surface rather than just following tutorials. In my internship with CSM Security, this shows in how I approach client communication — I ask a lot of questions about what they want from the application, how they envision using it, and what specific problems they need solved, because understanding the "why" behind a feature request matters more than jumping straight into code.

Humor is something I consider universal and essential. It makes any situation less intimidating — whether it is a confusing requirement, an awkward miscommunication, or a mistake in a meeting. Being able to laugh it off and move on keeps the atmosphere relaxed and productive. In a client-facing role where misunderstandings are inevitable, humor turns potential friction into a moment of connection rather than tension.

Hope — the belief that a good outcome can be achieved — is something I rely on when taking on a project with unknowns. My internship involves building a full business application from scratch with freedom over the technology stack. That requires confidence that the pieces will come together, even when the specification is still evolving.

Forgiveness surprised me slightly, but on reflection it makes sense in a collaborative context. Requirements change, feedback can be contradictory, and misunderstandings happen. Not holding onto frustration when a client changes direction or when priorities shift allows me to stay productive and maintain a good working relationship.

Honesty is central to how I communicate professionally. When discussing the project scope with my employer, I was transparent about what is feasible, what needs clarification, and where the risks are. I believe being upfront — even when the answer is "I do not know yet" — builds more trust than overpromising.

Overall, these strengths align well with the nature of my internship: an independent, clientfacing software development role that requires equal parts technical curiosity and professional communication.

Peer Feedback

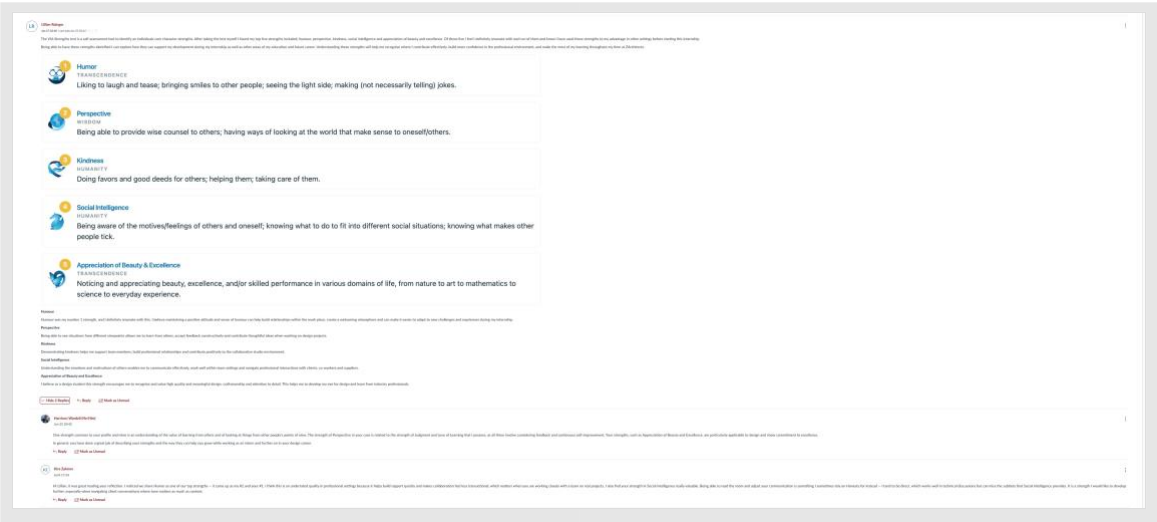


Figure 3 — Peer feedback to Lillian Reinger (shared Humor strength)

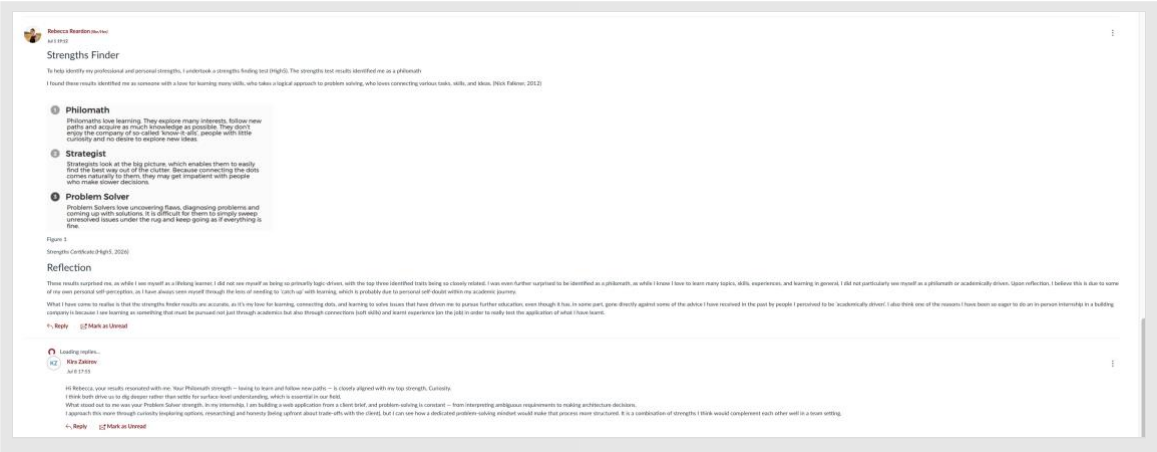


Figure 4 — Peer feedback to Rebecca Reardon (Philomath / Curiosity alignment)

PART C — THE STUDIO CULTURE EXPERIENCE

My internship with CSM Security operates primarily remotely. After an initial in-person meeting with Matt and Praveen to discuss the project scope and expectations, all subsequent communication has moved online. This is typical for Australian businesses, particularly those that work with external developers or contractors — the relationship is task-driven, and face-to-face meetings are reserved for key milestones rather than day-to-day check-ins.

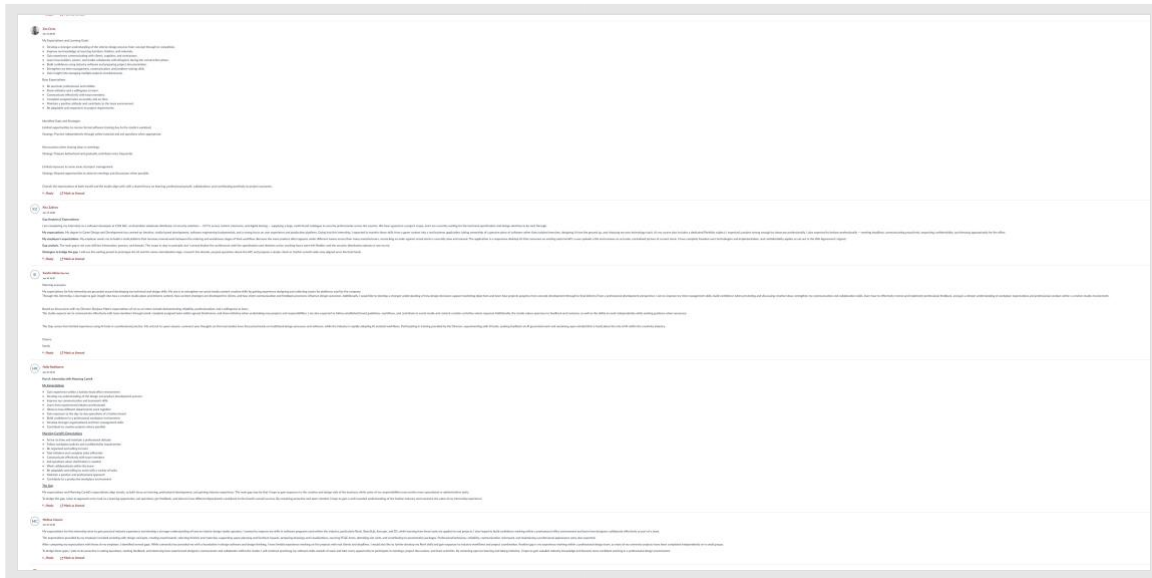


Figure 5 — Module 1 Discussion Forum: peer internship experiences for comparison

The working culture is professional and formal. Communication is respectful and to the point — messages tend to focus on deliverables, clarifications, and project updates rather than casual conversation. This suits the nature of the engagement: I am an external developer building a product for them, not a member of their internal team. There is a clear boundary between the client side and the development side, and both parties treat each other accordingly.

That said, from what I observed during our in-person meeting, their internal team dynamics are more varied. Some colleagues interact more casually with one another while others keep things strictly professional — which is normal for any mid-sized Australian workplace. People are generally polite and approachable, but like any company, not everything runs perfectly. Miscommunications happen, priorities shift without much notice, and not every piece of information arrives when you need it. These are not unique to CSM — they are realities of working in any organization.

This experience contrasts noticeably with those of my peers. Many of my classmates are embedded in-person within design studios — attending daily standups, observing senior designers, and absorbing culture through physical presence. My setup is closer to a freelance contractor model, where trust is built through deliverables and clear written communication rather than shared physical space. As Billett (2011) notes, workplace learning is shaped by the affordances the workplace provides; in my case, the affordance is autonomy and client-facing responsibility rather than guided mentorship.

This culture has shaped how I approach the project. Because our interactions are formal and infrequent, I have learned to make every communication count — preparing clear questions, documenting decisions in writing, and not relying on assumptions. The remote setup also means I need to be self-directed: there is no one sitting next to me to ask a quick question, so I plan my work around the information I have and flag blockers early. In many ways, this mirrors how freelance and contract development works in the Australian tech industry, making it a realistic and valuable professional experience.

PART D — TIME SHEET

WIL302 Internship Timesheet

Student Name: Kira ZakirovStudent ID: A00153068Supervisor name: Matt ParashisSubject Code: WIL302Assessment title: Assessment 1Supervisor contact: 0408 366 040

Date:	Duties:	Start time:	Finish time:	Total:
23/6/26	Website App	9	4	7
25/6/26	Website App	9	4	7
28/6/26	Website App	9	4	7
1/7/26	Website App	9	4	7
7/7/26	Website App	9	12	3
				Total: 31

Student signature: _____ Date: _____

Supervisor Signature: [Signature] Date: 8/7/26

Figure 6 — WIL302 Internship Timesheet (first 31 hours), signed by Matt Parashis

References

- Billett, S. (2011). *Curriculum and pedagogic bases for effectively integrating practice-based experiences*. Australian Learning and Teaching Council.
- Boud, D., & Solomon, N. (Eds.). (2001). *Work-based learning: A new higher education?* Society for Research into Higher Education & Open University Press.
- VIA Institute on Character. (2026). *VIA Character Strengths Survey*. <https://www.viacharacter.org/>

PART A — PERSONAL STUDIO INTERVIEW & ANALYSIS

For my interview I spoke with **Matt Parashis, National Marketing Manager at CSM SEC**, where I am doing my placement as a software developer. I chose Matt because he is not only a manager — he came up through design and web before moving into marketing, so his path was directly relevant to my own career questions about working across roles rather than in a single specialty.

1. What is your role, and what do you do day to day?

"I'm the National Marketing Manager, so I look after how the brand comes across — the website, catalogues, campaigns, and the material the sales teams rely on. Day to day it varies a lot; some days are planning and strategy, others I'm hands-on making sure things actually go out looking right. It's a broad role, which is what I like about it."

2. How would you describe your field?

"I'd say I sit between design and marketing. I started on the design side and moved into marketing over time, but I still approach things as a designer first — how something looks and communicates before anything else."

3. How did you get here?

"It wasn't a straight line. I started in design, gradually took on more web and digital work, and eventually moved into managing marketing. I mostly learned the industry on the job rather than planning it out. Being willing to take on whatever came up shaped my path more than any single decision."

4. What does a typical project look like?

"Often it's launching a new product range. It starts with understanding what we're trying to achieve and who we're talking to, then the creative side, then getting it out across our channels, and finally looking back at whether it worked. I stay involved start to finish, which I prefer."

5. Who do you work with?

"Quite a range — suppliers on one side, the sales and branch teams on the other, and outside help when a project needs it. Marketing sits in the middle, so a lot of the job is keeping everyone on the same page."

6. How do you make decisions when things are unclear?

"I go back to two questions: what are we actually trying to achieve, and who is it for. Coming from design, I'd rather put a rough version in front of people and get a reaction than debate it in the abstract. You learn far more from how people respond to something real."

7. Any advice for me?

"Don't narrow yourself too early. Being able to work across a few areas — design, development, whatever — is a real advantage. And being dependable matters as much as being talented; people come back to those they can rely on to deliver."

8. Where is the field heading?

"Everything's getting more digital and more automated, and the newer AI tools are starting to change how the work gets done. Our products keep getting more advanced, so there's more to explain to customers than there used to be. You never really stop learning."

Analysis & Key Takeaways

Three things from this conversation connect directly to my own goals as a developer. First, Matt's path is **not linear** — he moved from design into web and digital work and then into managing marketing, learning the industry as he went. His comment that "being willing to take on whatever came up shaped my path more than any single decision" reassured me that I do not have to lock myself into a single specialty to build a career. That maps onto what I value most about this placement: the chance to work across every role of a project rather than only writing code.

Second, his advice not to **"narrow yourself too early,"** and that "being dependable matters as much as being talented," reframed something I had underestimated. I tend to focus on technical decisions, but hearing a senior manager say that reliability is what makes people come back to you shifted how I think about professional value. It is not only what I can build, but whether I can be trusted to deliver it — something I want to carry into how I communicate and manage scope.

Third, his approach to uncertainty — **"I'd rather put a rough version in front of people and get a reaction than debate it in the abstract"** — is a practical method I can apply immediately. Much of my work involves choosing technologies and shaping requirements where the answer is not obvious; prototyping quickly and testing against real reactions is often better than over-analysing. Coming from a designer-turned-manager, that advice felt especially credible. Overall, the interview confirmed that breadth, dependability and a bias toward testing ideas in practice are exactly the qualities I should keep developing.

Analysis ≈ 300 words

**Kira Zakirov**
Aug 5 13:52

1. Role / day to day?
I'm the National Marketing Manager, so I look after how the brand comes across — the website, catalogues, campaigns, and the material the sales teams rely on. Day to day it varies a lot; some days are planning and strategy, others I'm hands-on making sure things actually go out looking right. It's a broad role, which is what I like about it.

2. Your field?
I'd say I sit between design and marketing. I started on the design side and moved into marketing over time, but I still approach things as a designer first — how something looks and communicates before anything else.

3. How did you get here?
It wasn't a straight line. I started in design, gradually took on more web and digital work, and eventually moved into managing marketing. I mostly learned the industry on the job rather than planning it out. Being willing to take on whatever came up shaped my path more than any single decision.

4. A typical project?
Often it's launching a new product range. It starts with understanding what we're trying to achieve and who we're talking to, then the creative side, then getting it out across our channels, and finally looking back at whether it worked. I stay involved start to finish, which I prefer.

5. Who do you work with?
Quite a range — suppliers on one side, the sales and branch teams on the other, and outside help when a project needs it. Marketing sits in the middle, so a lot of the job is keeping everyone on the same page.

6. Decisions when things are unclear?
I go back to two questions: what are we actually trying to achieve, and who is it for? Coming from design, I'd rather put a rough version in front of people and get a reaction than debate it in the abstract. You learn far more from how people respond to something real.

7. Advice for me?
Don't narrow yourself too early. Being able to work across a few areas — design, development, whatever — is a real advantage. And being dependable matters as much as being talented; people come back to those they can rely on to deliver.

8. Where's the field heading?
Everything's getting more digital and more automated, and the newer AI tools are starting to change how the work gets done. Our products keep getting more advanced, so there's more to explain to customers than there used to be. You never really stop learning.

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Figure 7 — Studio interview questions & answers shared on the Module 3 Discussion Forum.

PART B — STUDIO WORKFLOW & PROCESS

Because CSM engages me as an external, remote developer, a "job" does not move around a physical studio floor — it moves through a **client ↔ developer pipeline** built on written documents and approval gates. The flowchart below maps how my stocktaking-app project actually travels, from the client's brief through to handover.

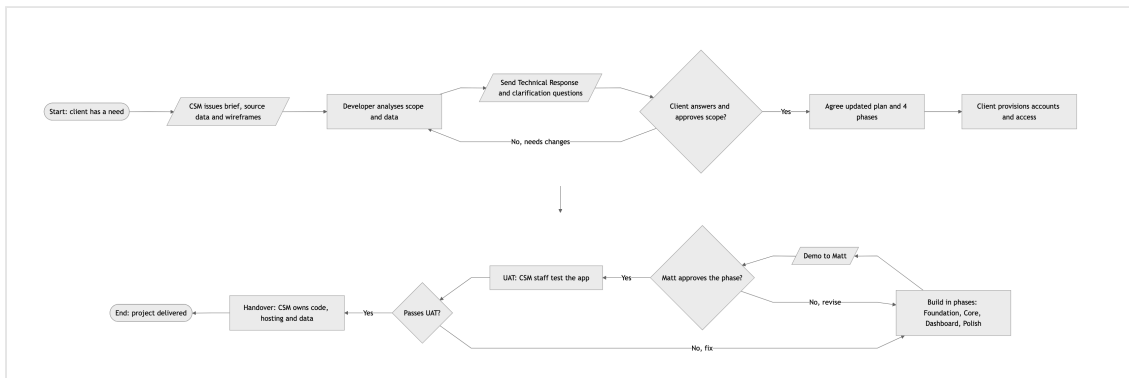


Figure 8 — Stocktaking project workflow: how the job moves from client to developer and back, with revision loops.

Analysis of the Process

Projects here are **not always run the same way** — the depth of the pipeline scales with the size and risk of the job. A large, ambiguous build like the stocktaking app warranted formal written stages and explicit sign-off gates; a small change request would skip straight to a quick message and a same-day fix. Process is added only where the cost of a misunderstanding is high, which keeps it efficient.

The studio relies almost entirely on **asynchronous, written communication** — email and documents (the Technical Response and Clarification Outcomes) rather than a proprietary job-management system — with face-to-face reserved for the kick-off and key milestones. Quality is protected by the three **decision gates** shown in the diagram (scope sign-off, phase demos to Matt, and UAT) and their revision loops: nothing large proceeds without Matt's explicit approval, and the final handover is de-risked because CSM owns the accounts from the start, so there is nothing to migrate.

When the access provisioning was delayed, I did not stop — I started the Foundation phase **locally**, decoupling the work that did not need the accounts from the work that did. Overall I think it is an efficient model for a remote engagement of this kind. As Billett (2011) observes, the way a workplace is structured shapes the learning it affords; here that affordance is autonomy and written, client-facing responsibility rather than close supervision. Responses occasionally come slowly, as they did with the first scope document, but that is a normal part of working with a real business that is balancing this alongside its other priorities, rather than a systemic problem.

≈ 300 words

PART C — APPLYING MY STRENGTHS

Gallup describes five clues to talent — *yearning*, *rapid learning*, *flow*, *satisfaction* and *glimpses of excellence* (Buckingham & Clifton, 2001). Reading my internship through these, and through my VIA top-five strengths,^{*} makes it clear which tasks energise me and why.

What draws me most is the chance to **run a project across all its roles, not just as a coder** — from the first client conversation and requirements analysis to choosing the technology and building it. Development has been my passion for years, so this move beyond a single role gives me real *yearning* and *satisfaction*: I own the outcome end to end. That pull is powered by my **Curiosity** — I genuinely want to hear and account for every client request and understand the "why" behind a requirement before writing any code.

Curiosity also explains why choosing technologies feels like *flow* rather than a chore. Proper analysis is not grabbing whatever is popular — it is finding what fits this specific project, which takes time but is where my *glimpses of excellence* show. And when a technology is new to me, that is not a barrier but *rapid learning*, which I always welcome.

The strengths work together. **Hope** gives me the confidence to take on a full, uncertain project and stay with it through the long analysis stage. **Honesty** shows in documentation — not my favourite part, but the work is not complete without it, so finishing it properly is a matter of professional integrity. **Forgiveness** keeps me calm when requirements shift or replies take a while. And **Humor** keeps communication easy — working with my supervisor has been genuinely comfortable and productive. Overall, I am at my best in product work that runs from requirement to delivery, where curiosity, learning and honesty meet.

≈ 300 words

^{*} Consistent with Assessment 1, my strengths were identified via the VIA Character Strengths survey (top five: Curiosity, Humor, Hope, Forgiveness, Honesty). Here I interpret them through Gallup's five clues-to-talent framework, as directed in the brief.

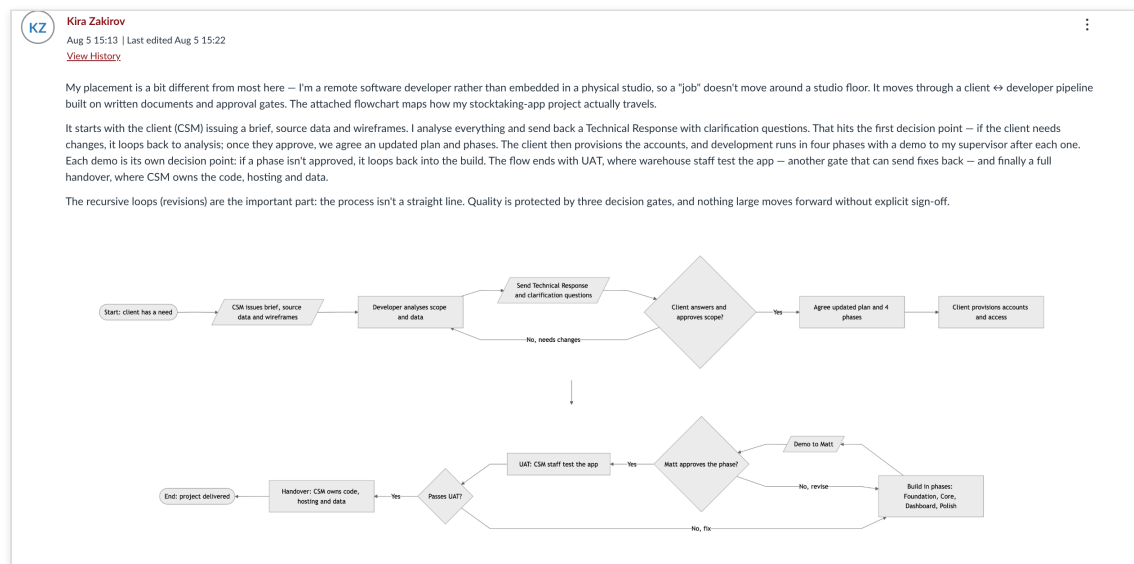


Figure 9 — My studio workflow diagram & description posted to the Module 4.2 Discussion Forum.

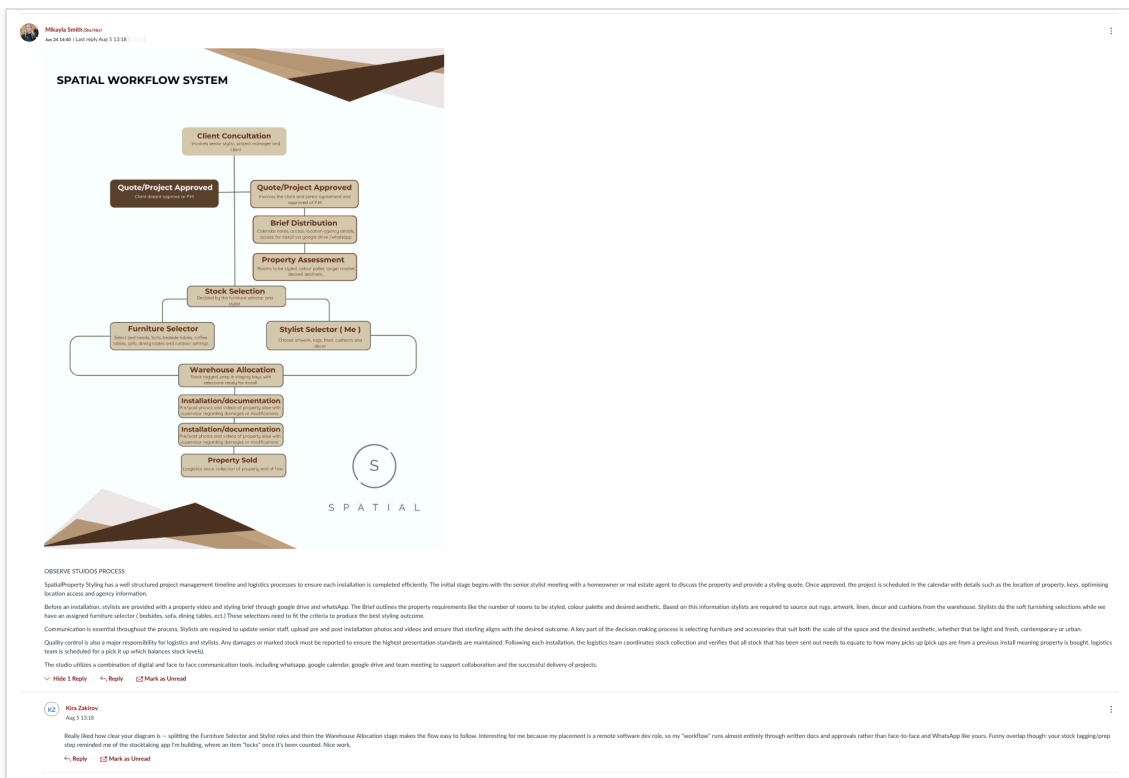


Figure 10 — My comment on Mikayla Smith's workflow post (peer 1 of 2).

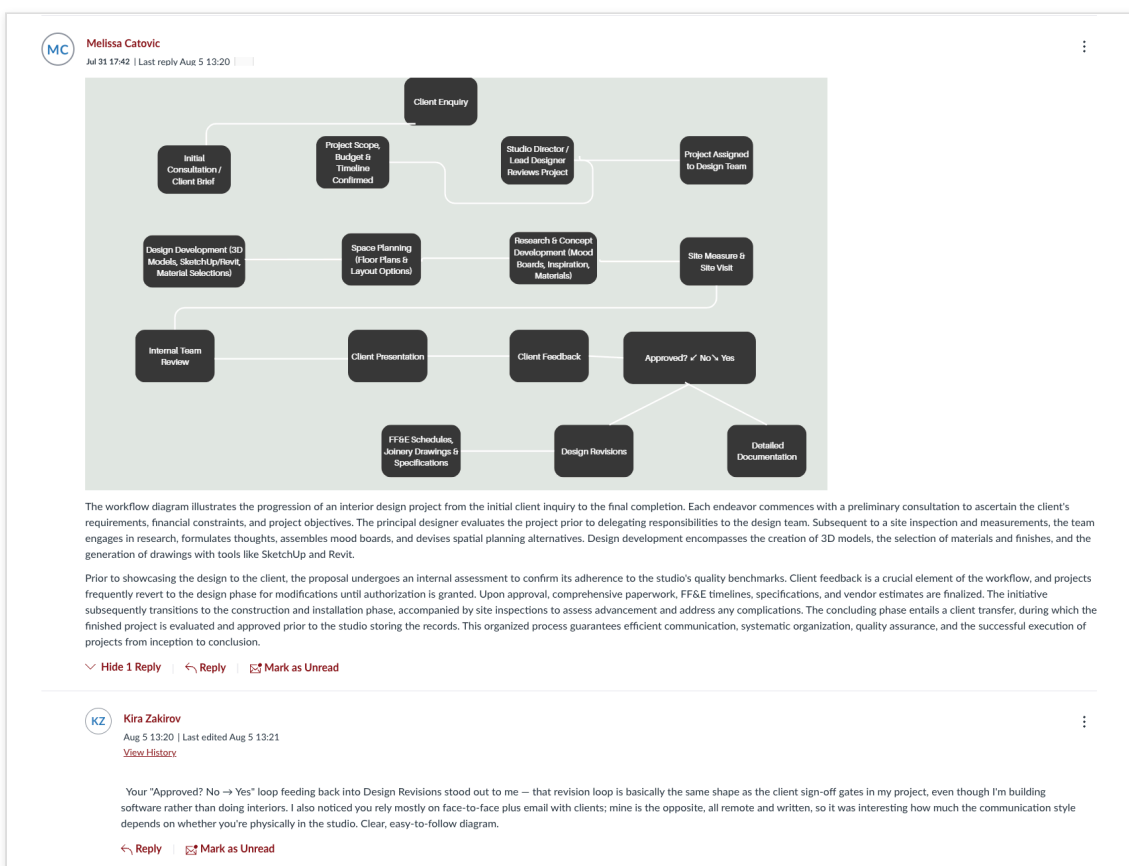


Figure 11 — My comment on Melissa Catovic's workflow post (peer 2 of 2).

PART D — TIME SHEET

WIL302 Internship Timesheet

Student Name: Kira Zakirov Student ID: A00153068 Supervisor name: Matt Parashis
Subject Code: WIL302 Assessment title: A1 Supervisor contact: 0408 366 040

Date:	Duties:	Start time:	Finish time:	Total:
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1/8/26	Website App	9	12	3
				Total: 31

Student signature: [Signature] Date: 05/08/2026
Supervisor Signature: [Signature] Date: 5/8/26

Figure 12 — WIL302 Internship Timesheet (hours 31–60), signed by supervisor Matt Parashis.

References

- Billett, S. (2011). *Curriculum and pedagogic bases for effectively integrating practice-based experiences*. Australian Learning and Teaching Council.
Buckingham, M., & Clifton, D. O. (2001). *Now, discover your strengths*. The Free Press.
VIA Institute on Character. (2026). *VIA Character Strengths Survey*. <https://www.viacharacter.org/>

STUDIO POSITIONING, COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT & PERSONAL REFLECTION

Trimester 3, 2026

Its main contribution is educational and technical: **specialised product training and ongoing backup support** that lift installer competence across the industry, which is the trade equivalent of mentoring. It also works closely with manufacturers, supporting product-training and "discovery"-style events that keep the wider channel current. During my placement I did not observe pro-bono design projects, registered-charity work, or design-award entries — unsurprising for this segment, where value is delivered B2B rather than through public creative campaigns. CSM's community impact is practical and infrastructural: by keeping thousands of

installers stocked, trained and supported, it underwrites the reliability of the security systems that end-users ultimately depend on.

≈ 150 words

TRUSTED EXPERTS IN ADVANCED SECURITY SOLUTIONS

ABOUT CSM

Innovative and reliable security solutions for professionals across Australia



TRUSTED EXPERTS IN
ADVANCED SECURITY SOLUTIONS

WE ARE CSM! We supply innovative and reliable security solutions to security professionals in Australia. We are a team of like-minded security experts with an enviable reputation for expertise and trusted business relationships making us your supplier of choice.

CSM has five branches across Australia and offers a full range of security products that cover everything you need for your next install. In addition, our unwavering commitment to customer service and business relationships provides a solid foundation to help your business grow and succeed.

Interacting extensively with security users and specifiers, we offer direct wholesale supplies, warehouse facilities, specialized training, and a high level of backup support, specifically geared to meet market demands and your needs as a security installer.

Figure 15 — "About CSM": its emphasis on specialised training and backup support to security professionals — its main channel of contribution to the industry community.

PART C — REFLECTION ON HOW MY STRENGTHS CONTRIBUTED TO MY PERFORMANCE

Reflecting on the second half of my internship, I can see where I intentionally leaned on my top-five strengths^{*} to push through obstacles — and, occasionally, where I overplayed them.

My **Curiosity** did the heavy lifting. Before writing code I wanted to understand the security-distribution domain and the "why" behind every requirement, so I asked Matt targeted questions and documented each decision rather than assuming. Paired with **Honesty**, this kept scope realistic: when something was not yet feasible, or I did not know an answer, I said so instead of overpromising — which built trust across an entirely remote relationship.

Hope and **Forgiveness** carried me through the project's rougher moments. When account access was delayed and replies sometimes came slowly, I stayed confident the pieces would come together and did not let the hold-ups frustrate me — I simply re-sequenced the work. **Humor** kept the communication light and the working relationship comfortable, even when a requirement was confusing.

There were clearly times I **overplayed** my strengths. My Curiosity tipped into over-analysis: I spent too long comparing technology options in search of the "perfect" stack, which delayed the start — my version of spending too much time in Ideation. I also took on too much Responsibility, deciding architecture alone rather than checking in earlier. Recognising this, I began time-boxing research and surfacing decisions sooner.

Thinking forward, my greatest challenge will be establishing myself in commercial software as a generalist coming from a game-design degree — building credibility, a network, and the confidence to make calls under real stakes. To meet it I will draw on **Curiosity** for the rapid learning that fills knowledge gaps, **Hope** for the persistence long goals demand, and **Honesty** to keep earning the trust that, as Matt put it, makes people come back to those they can rely on.

≈ 300 words

^{*} Consistent with Assessments 1 & 2, my strengths were identified via the VIA Character Strengths survey (top five: Curiosity, Humor, Hope, Forgiveness, Honesty), here interpreted through Gallup's strengths framework as directed in the brief.

**Kira Zakirov**
Aug 13 16:13

Applying my strengths — reflection on my internship.

Looking back on my internship at CSM SEC as a remote software developer, I can see where I intentionally leaned on my top-five strengths — Curiosity, Humour, Hope, Forgiveness and Honesty* — to overcome obstacles, and occasionally where I overplayed them.

My Curiosity did the heavy lifting. Before writing code, I wanted to understand the security-distribution domain and the "why" behind every requirement, so I asked my supervisor targeted questions and documented each decision rather than assuming. Paired with Honesty, this kept scope realistic: when something wasn't yet feasible, or I didn't know an answer, I said so instead of overpromising — which built trust across an entirely remote relationship.

Hope and Forgiveness carried me through the rougher moments. When account access was delayed, and replies sometimes came slowly, I stayed confident the pieces would come together and didn't let the hold-ups frustrate me — I simply re-sequenced the work and started what I could locally. Humour kept communication light and the working relationship comfortable, even when a requirement was confusing.

Overplayed talents. There were clearly times I pushed a strength too far. My Curiosity tipped into over-analysis — I spent too long comparing technology options in search of the "perfect" stack, which delayed the start (my version of too much time in Ideation). I also took on too much Responsibility, deciding architecture alone rather than checking in earlier. Recognising this, I began time-boxing research and surfacing decisions sooner.

Looking forward, my greatest challenge will be establishing myself in commercial software as a generalist coming from a game-design degree — building credibility, a network, and the confidence to make calls under real stakes. To meet it, I'll draw on Curiosity for rapid learning, Hope for persistence, and Honesty to keep earning trust.

Keen to hear from others — did anyone else catch themselves overplaying a strength on the job?

 Reply |  Mark as Unread

Figure 16 — My strengths reflection posted to the Module 6 Discussion Forum.

GD

Grace Dunn

Aug 2 21:43

STRENGTH REFLECTION

Completing my Gallup strengths assessment helped me better understand why certain aspects of my role at Manning Cartell are both motivating and rewarding. Gallup identifies five indicators of talent: yearning, rapid learning, flow, satisfaction, and glimpses of excellence, all of which I experienced throughout my job as the design assistant.

I felt the strongest sense of yearning when contributing to product development and collaborating with different departments. Coordinating fit sessions, communicating with overseas manufacturers, and leading weekly production meetings showed me that I am most engaged when solving problems and helping projects progress efficiently. Rather than simply completing tasks, I enjoyed understanding how each decision influenced the final product.

Rapid learning occurred because every collection introduced new challenges. I actively asked questions during design handovers, fit sessions, and production meetings to understand garment construction, technical packs, supplier communication, and production processes. This curiosity helped me build confidence while developing stronger technical and commercial knowledge.

The greatest sense of flow came from managing multiple responsibilities across departments. Organising production meetings, maintaining collection trackers, preparing fit sessions, and communicating with suppliers required organisation, adaptability, and clear communication. As my confidence increased, I became more proactive in leading discussions, anticipating production issues, and suggesting solutions. These experiences strengthened my decision-making and demonstrated that I perform best in collaborative, fast-paced environments.

The greatest satisfaction came from seeing garments progress from an initial concept through sampling, fittings, photoshoots, and ultimately into stores. Being involved throughout the entire product development process reinforced my passion for fashion design and highlighted the importance of teamwork in achieving successful outcomes. This internship confirmed that my strengths extend beyond creativity to include leadership, communication, and collaboration. Moving forward, I will continue building my technical expertise and commercial awareness while developing the confidence to lead multidisciplinary teams, supporting my long-term goal of becoming a fashion designer and progressing into a design management role.

↩️ Reply

🚩 Mark as Unread

Harrison Wardell

Aug 2 21:59

Your reflection was very interesting to me, as you managed to connect your strengths to real responsibilities during the internship. The fact that you cited examples of coordinating production meetings, communicating with overseas manufacturers, and participating in fit sessions demonstrated that you applied your strengths in practice, not just in theory.

What I especially like is your reflection on the state of flow while handling multiple responsibilities. It proves that you enjoy working in a fast-paced, collaborative environment and do not hesitate to be proactive across different teams. What I also find encouraging is your reflection on the development of the garment from the conceptual idea to the item on the shop floor, as it underscores the importance of understanding the whole process, not just its separate aspects.

↩️ Reply

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KZ

Kira Zakirov

Aug 13 16:15

Hi Grace, I really enjoyed this — we approached the reflection through the same Gallup lens (yearning, rapid learning, flow, satisfaction), so it was fascinating to see it play out in a completely different field. Your strongest sense of yearning coming from being involved across the whole product — from concept through to garments in store — mirrors exactly what drives me: I get the most satisfaction from seeing a project end to end, from the client brief to the delivered application, rather than one slice of it. Your rapid learning through constantly asking questions in handovers and fit sessions also resonated; asking “why” has been my main way of building confidence in an unfamiliar domain. Wishing you the best moving toward a design-management role.

↩️ Reply

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Figure 17 — My comment on Grace Dunn's strengths reflection (1 of 2).

Harrison Wardell

Aug 2 19:37 | Last reply Aug 13 16:14

Gallup Strengths Application

Top 5 Strengths Check

1. Leadership

2. Kindness

3. Love of Learning

4. Teamwork

5. Humour

Positive Obstacle Navigation

During my internship, I have noticed that my strengths have heavily influenced how I react to challenges when they arise, especially during the website refresh.

My strongest skill, as listed, is Leadership, which became very clear to me when I was given responsibility for redesigning sections of the website. Even though I have been an intern during this journey, I was able to take ownership of tasks, organising meetings and presenting ideas to Nina, Kris, Mary-Rose and Eve. I waited only briefly for direction from my mentors during this project. I was proactive in identifying areas for improvement, asking questions, and ensuring the project was progressing. This helped my development and confidence, whilst I have been able to contribute meaningful ideas to the team.

Other skills that have played a significant role within my internship are kindness. Throughout my time within the team, I have worked alongside professionals from different departments, including UX/UI, client engagement and stakeholder engagement. Each department brought different perspectives to the project. I have listened carefully, been approachable and respectful of feedback, and shown that I am a positive person to work with, creating an environment that made collaboration feel more comfortable. This skill has also helped me understand the needs of Beaumont Care's residents and their families, ensuring my empathy is central to design decisions.

Love for Learning is one of my most valuable skills. With the website design and UX/UI areas where I am not as confident, I was intrigued and wanted to learn more. I consistently asked Nina and Kris for feedback throughout my internship, researched accessibility needs and explored different approaches. With every revision, it was an opportunity to improve and build my skills, and to gain a better understanding of how web design progresses.

What effectively supported my collaboration was my teamwork skill. Each page required input from multiple departments. I learned that projects rely heavily on continuous communication across departments rather than individual decision-making. Through regular meetings, emails, and collaboration and feedback, this helped ensure that the website's outcome reflected the organisation's branding, accessibility standards, and client needs.

And finally, Humour, this skill helped me create positive relationships with the team, even though we were all working remotely. Maintaining a friendly attitude throughout meetings made communication feel more comfortable, strengthened our rapport, and made contributions more enjoyable while working in a professional environment.

Overplayed Talents

Even though I saw how my strengths helped me throughout my internship, I noticed some limitations with them.

When it comes to my Love of Learning, I sometimes notice myself spending too much time researching, specifically on certain design choices, before getting into the technical side. Even though the research did strengthen my knowledge in areas I was less educated in, mostly around UX/UI design and accessibility, every so often, it would delay me in making design decisions because I was Tweedle my time in researching every solution. Within a professional environment, deadlines are important. I had to learn that there is a balance between research and execution.

When it came to my leadership, it occasionally led me to take on more responsibilities than I could handle. This is because I wanted to contribute wherever possible. Whilst it is important to take initiative, I realised that collaboration also involved trusting the team I was working with and recognising when I needed to take a step back rather than trying to solve all the problems by myself.

Another difficulty I faced was my Kindness. It was difficult for me to challenge other team members' ideas and provide critical feedback on certain parts of the project. I would get worried that it would interfere with the positive relationships I had with the team. Throughout my time with the team, I built my confidence and became more comfortable giving critical feedback. It is an important aspect of collaboration and leads to stronger outcomes.

Future Growth Plan

At the beginning of my journey into the realm of communication design, one of my greatest obstacles was the shift from designing for college courses to designing in fast-moving professional environments, where deadlines, clients, and business considerations shape the design process.

For this reason, I intend to continue refining my Love of Learning to learn about topics such as UX/UI design, accessibility, Figma, and motion graphics.

Leadership will also help me gain the confidence to present my ideas and communicate with clients, while ensuring I keep an open mind to collaboration and do not try to handle everything myself. The teamwork and kindness skills I have will be very helpful in building positive relationships with colleagues and clients, enabling me to work effectively in multidisciplinary groups. Lastly, a good sense of humour will make me always approachable and resilient.

In summary, through this internship experience, I have come to understand that apart from design abilities, my strengths influence my communication, problem-solving, teamwork and attitude.

🗲 Hide 1 Reply

↩️ Reply

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KZ

Kira Zakirov

Aug 13 16:14

Hi Harrison, this was a really thorough reflection and I recognised a lot of my own internship in it. We share Humour in our top five, and it's interesting we both leaned on it to keep remote communication comfortable. The part that struck me most was your overplayed Love of Learning — I had the exact same issue with Curiosity, disappearing into research for the “perfect” solution before committing, and having to learn where research ends and execution begins under a real deadline. I also related to taking on too much responsibility rather than trusting the process. And your point about Kindness making critical feedback harder was a good reminder that even a strength that smooths collaboration has a cost. Great job tying each strength to real tasks on the Beaumont Care redesign.

↩️ Reply

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Figure 18 — My comment on Harrison Wardell's strengths reflection (2 of 2).

PART D — MY CREATIVE JOURNEY: A PERSONAL REFLECTION

Introduction to my journey

I spent my internship as a **remote software developer at CSM SEC**, building an internal stocktaking web application to replace the static Excel export the warehouse teams had been relying on from NetSuite. My responsibility was the whole product — scoping it with the client, choosing the technology, and building it — rather than a single ticket. I expected to transfer my degree's studio-based development skills into a real business setting, and to behave professionally: meeting deadlines, communicating proactively and respecting confidentiality. Studio life was asynchronous and self-directed, with Matt Parashis as my mentor and main point of contact.

Skills and knowledge — on the job

Two critical incidents shaped the experience. The first was a **delay in receiving account and system access**. Rather than stall, I decoupled the work — starting the Foundation phase locally on everything that did not depend on live data, so momentum never broke. The second was **choosing the technology stack alone**. With complete freedom and no supervisor approving each step, I owned every architectural decision, which was both the most rewarding and the most exposing part of the placement. Along the way I gained genuinely new skills: client-facing scoping, writing a structured technical response, and self-directed decision-making under ambiguity. I also confronted real ethical responsibility — handling CSM's product and inventory data under the confidentiality terms of my WIL agreement, and being honest in scoping rather than overpromising. Critically, my strength was ownership and curiosity; my weakness was a slow, over-analytical start and a tendency to decide in isolation, which I corrected by time-boxing and communicating earlier.

Theory and study vs professional practice

My Bachelor of Game Design and Development centred on iterative, studio-based development, software-engineering fundamentals, production pipelines and a strong user-experience focus — plus a dedicated Portfolio subject. Much of this connected directly to the internship: the iterative, prototype-and-test mindset I learned at university mapped cleanly onto building a business tool feature by feature, and my UX training shaped how I designed the stocktaking interface for warehouse staff working under time pressure. The sharpest contrast was structure. University work came as self-contained exercises with a clear brief and rubric; the internship gave me one real product, one real client and genuine ambiguity, with no rubric to check against. This is exactly what Boud and Solomon (2001) describe as the core of work-based learning — competence developed by navigating real workplace challenges — and what Billett (2011) frames as the learning a workplace affords through its structure; here, autonomy and client-facing responsibility.

The conclusion of my journey

The key learning I take away is that I do my best work when I **own a product end to end**, from requirement to delivery, and that professional value is as much about being dependable and communicating clearly as it is about technical skill. At the outset I felt prepared technically but uncertain about the client-facing, self-directed side; I now feel genuinely more confident in both. For the next chapter I plan to keep deepening my full-stack skills, seek out more real projects rather than isolated exercises, and hold onto the breadth Matt advised — not narrowing myself too early — as I move from this placement into a commercial software career.

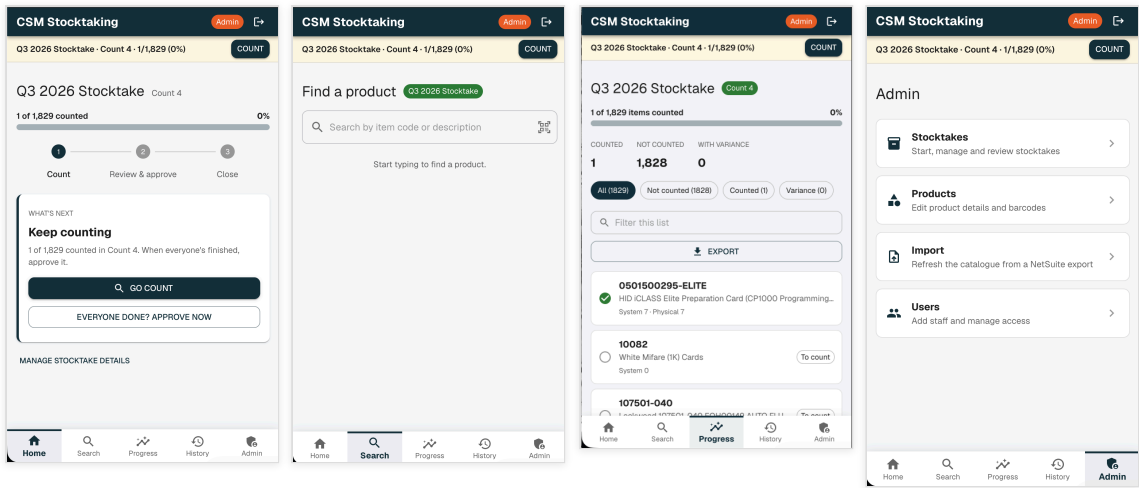


Figure 19 — The internal stocktaking web application I built for CSM: live count progress, product search, item tracking with variance and export, and an admin panel that refreshes the catalogue from a NetSuite export.

PART E — TIME SHEET



WIL Internship Timesheet

Student Name: Kira Zakirov Student ID: A00153068

Supervisor name: Matt Parashis

Subject Code: WIL302 Assessment title: Assessment 3

Supervisor Contact: 0408366040

Date:	Duties:	Start time:	Finish time:	Total:
04/08	Website app	10	18	8
05/08	Website app	10	14	4
06/08	Website app	13	18	5
10/08	Website app	17	22	5
11/08	Website app	10	14	4
12/08	Website app	12	16	4
				Total:30

Student signature:

Date: 13/08/2026

WIL302 Internship Timesheet

1

Figure 20 — WIL302 Internship Timesheet (hours 61–90), signed by supervisor Matt Parashis.

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